



POLITICS **IN** **NIGERIA**

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DEDICATION

To all citizens of Nigeria committed to national progress.

PREFACE

Politics in Nigeria! There is no way we can discuss Nigerian politics without mentioning the keyword “Democracy.”

The word democracy comes from the Greek words ‘demos’, meaning people, and ‘kratos’, meaning power. Hence, democracy can be understood as the “power of the people,” a way of governing that depends on the will of the people.

According to Schumpeter (1947), democracy means that the people can accept or reject those who are to govern them. By this, democracy implies conducting elections and choosing leaders who will represent the majority.

Democracy is government by the people. It is a form of government in which supreme power is vested in the people and exercised directly by them or through their elected agents under a free electoral system.

Before democracy in Nigeria, the system of governance was based on military rule. During those periods, absolute power rested solely with the government. The opinion of the people could not dictate government decisions because there was no opportunity to vote or be voted for, and there was no concept of political parties.

However, democracy makes it possible for citizens to be actively involved in choosing their leaders. Hence, people participate in the process of forming a government. They have free will and the right to vote for parties and leaders of their choice. And this right is universal and is not restricted by wealth, social class, or ethnicity.

In a democratic system, different parties present a manifesto or a set of ideas about how a country should be governed. Thus, a democratic government is formed when a majority of people support a particular party as the ruling party.

Undoubtedly, the democratic system of government is a demonstration of political activity. Thus, politics can be described as the activities involved in the making of government or the functioning of government.

Politics is a broad institution comprising different categories of people with varying ideologies. Politics may be bound by certain rules and regulations, yet its deeper activities require intelligence and participation.

So, what can we say about political activity in Nigeria? Everything about these activities (both cunning and unwise) is what will be discussed in this book.

Therefore, this book will focus on four major topics:

- ❖ Political parties
- ❖ Elections
- ❖ Appointments
- ❖ Governance

ELECTION

An election is a process through which people vote to choose a person or a group of people to hold public office.

Elections make a fundamental contribution to democracy. And the primary purpose of conducting elections is to express the sovereign power of the people. Through elections, citizens participate directly in governance by choosing those who will represent them.

Thus, elections enable voters to select leaders and hold them accountable for their performance in office. They also provide political education for citizens and ensure that democratic governments remain responsive to the will of the people.

In Nigeria, elections are conducted periodically for various political offices across the thirty-six states and the Federal Capital Territory.

The Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) is the body established by the Constitution to conduct and supervise elections in Nigeria. Its responsibilities cover elections for the offices of the President, members of the Senate and House of Representatives,

Governors, members of the State Houses of Assembly, and other elective political positions.

INEC is also responsible for the registration of political parties in accordance with the provisions of the Constitution. It monitors the organisation and operations of political parties, including their finances, conventions, congresses, and party primaries.

The Commission arranges for the annual examination and auditing of the funds and accounts of political parties and publishes reports on such examinations and audits for public information.

Other functions of INEC include monitoring political campaigns and issuing rules and regulations that govern the activities of political parties. The Commission also promotes knowledge of sound democratic electoral processes and conducts referendums when required by the 1999 Constitution or any other Act of the National Assembly.

INEC is expected to carry out its duties independently and free from external influence. It is also expected to demonstrate openness and transparency in all its activities and in its relationship with stakeholders.

The electoral process in Nigeria is structured to be conducted in an organised manner and is divided into various stages, each of which plays a vital role in the overall process. These stages include:

- ❖ **Primary elections** (pre-electoral stage): This is a preliminary election in which a political party selects its preferred candidate

to contest public office under its platform. During this stage, parties reduce the pool of aspirants to a single candidate who will represent them in the general election.

- ❖ **Nomination:** At this stage, political parties formally announce their flag bearers for the respective political offices.
- ❖ Campaigning.
- ❖ Voting.
- ❖ Collation and counting votes.
- ❖ Declaration of results.

Thus, these stages constitute the framework through which elections are conducted in Nigeria. However, each stage is often associated with various challenges, which makes it difficult to achieve a smooth and credible electoral process in the country.

The questions that arise at this point are as follows: what structures do political parties use in selecting candidates during elections? How are political campaigns conducted in Nigeria? What problems are associated with elections in the country, and why do many citizens abstain from voting? Finally, what steps are necessary to achieve a well-organised electoral process in Nigeria? These issues form the focus of this chapter.

Beginning with the structure political parties use in selecting candidates to represent them in elections, it is evident that over the years this process has been largely ineffective. The procedures adopted

by many political parties in choosing candidates and presenting manifestos have remained below acceptable standards. Parties often repeat the same mistakes, and the most troubling aspect is that opposition parties rarely take advantage of the weaknesses in their rivals' choices. Instead, most parties adopt similar approaches, leaving voters confused and unable to distinguish meaningful differences among candidates.

Past elections often left voters wondering which candidate to support. When political candidates appear to share similar negative reputations, making the right decision is extremely difficult.

The candidate selection process is so poor that it feels like being asked to choose between two equally undesirable options. And this confusion in voters' minds produces two common outcomes during elections.

First, some eligible voters still vote for a candidate of their choice, even though the choice is limited. In such cases, voters are forced to select what they perceive as the least harmful option among candidates.

Second, other voters vote against a particular candidate rather than in genuine support of another. In this situation, voters are motivated not by preference, but by a desire to prevent a specific candidate or manifesto from succeeding.

As a result, many past and present leaders have been elected not because they were the most competent or deserving, but because of the poor candidate selection structures within political parties. Undoubtedly, this situation has had several negative consequences for national development and democratic governance.

Turning to the issue of how political campaigns are conducted in Nigeria. Once political parties have selected their candidates and adopted their manifestos, attention shifts to campaigning.

A political campaign is an organised effort aimed at influencing decision-making within a specific group, particularly voters during an electoral period. Electoral campaigns serve as the means through which candidates and political parties present their ideas, policies, and positions to the electorate in the period preceding an election.

Campaigning plays an important role in informing voters, ensuring freedom of choice, and providing contestants with a fair opportunity to gain support. It allows candidates and parties to communicate their messages to citizens and helps voters make informed decisions on election day. And to achieve this, candidates and parties employ various methods, including traditional and news media, public rallies, printed materials such as flyers and banners, and other communication channels.

Strangely, political campaigns in Nigeria have increasingly taken on a commercial character. Many political parties approach

campaigns as financial investments, with the expectation of long-term returns once they gain power. For some citizens, the campaign period has also become an opportunity for personal economic gain rather than civic engagement.

Political campaigns in Nigeria frequently involve cunning and deceitful strategies, whereby candidates and their respective political parties manipulate voters to secure support rather than genuinely inform them. To explain this more clearly, two common patterns can be observed.

First, since politicians frequently treat campaigns as investments. The behaviour and tactics displayed during campaign periods are often striking, as many politicians engage in activities they would normally avoid. Various acts of generosity and public concern are suddenly displayed for political purposes, even though citizens may perceive these same individuals quite differently outside the campaign period.

Visiting a public barber shop, walking around the local community, buying food in the market, using public buses and motorcycles, sharing foodstuffs and other items, exchanging money, and many more are some of the activities carried out by politicians during campaigns.

Promises are another major tool in political campaigns. Politicians often exploit current problems across the country to advance

their agendas. This is particularly troubling because, during every electoral period, the same promises are repeated regarding issues that have persisted for years, yet little or nothing is done to resolve them. The examples mentioned above represent just a few of the tactics employed by Nigerian politicians.

Calling politicians “advocates of the devil” is not without reason. Just as the devil deceives humans with earthly temptations in exchange for their souls, politicians in Nigeria often deceive citizens in exchange for national wealth.

Moving on to the problems associated with elections in Nigeria, it is evident from past elections that the country’s electoral processes have often fallen short of expectations. Various forms of electoral manipulation continue to obstruct the conduct of credible, free, and fair elections.

A key term associated with these problems is “election rigging.” Election rigging refers to electoral fraud or interference with the election process, sometimes called election manipulation, voter fraud, or vote-rigging. It involves illegal actions intended to increase the vote share of a favoured candidate or to decrease that of others.

Other forms of electoral manipulation include impersonation, multiple voting, deliberate shortages of voting materials, and interference by electoral bodies themselves. According to Nwabueze (2003), election rigging refers to palpable illegalities committed with

corrupt, fraudulent, or sinister motives to influence an election in favour of certain candidates, such as:

- ❖ Illegal voting
- ❖ Bribery
- ❖ Threatening and undue influence
- ❖ Intimidation or other forms of coercion of the electorate
- ❖ Falsification of results

The next point of discussion is why people often ignore voting in Nigeria. There are many reasons why citizens may choose not to vote.

Voting is defined as the expression of an individual's opinion or choice, especially in an election. It is also a fundamental process in a democratic system, allowing eligible voters to have a say in who represents them in political office.

Civic engagement in the political process is a key indicator of a healthy democracy. However, when citizens are frustrated or disappointed by patterns of government behaviour, they may withdraw from the electoral process, resulting in political apathy.

Political apathy refers to a lack of interest in politics and participation in political activities. Voter apathy is a related concept,

describing a lack of interest among eligible voters in participating in elections within representative democracies.

In Nigeria, political and voter apathy are prevalent due to a variety of factors, including:

- ❖ **Alienation:** Voters may feel that the political system does not work for them, making efforts to influence it seem futile.
- ❖ **Lack of variety among candidates:** Limited choice or the absence of qualified candidates discourages citizen participation. Many believe that voting will not result in meaningful change.
- ❖ **Environmental factors:** Physical environment, distance to polling stations, security concerns, and health challenges can deter voting. Media coverage can exacerbate these perceptions, sometimes presenting situations as worse than they actually are.
- ❖ Illiteracy
- ❖ The belief that a vote does not count
- ❖ Dislike of manifestos
- ❖ Lack of trust in government: Citizens who have voted for years with little visible improvement may become frustrated.
- ❖ Incompetence of the electoral body

It is important to note that while abstention can sometimes be a personal choice, high rates of political apathy in a country usually indicate deeper issues.

Moving on to the final discussion in this chapter: what are the solutions to the electoral problems in Nigeria? Without doubt, there is a need for long-lasting measures that not only curb these issues but also prevent many political and electoral challenges from recurring.

One major step towards a lasting solution is the implementation of proper regulations. While regulations exist, difficulties in conducting organised elections persist. We cannot rely on rules that were drafted fifteen or twenty years ago; regulations must evolve with the times. Methods that successfully addressed electoral manipulation in previous elections may not be effective in future contests.

Proper regulations are necessary for all electoral activities, including campaigns, voting, counting and collation of results, and transportation of ballot boxes. It is regrettable that, in this age of advanced technology, elections in Nigeria still face transparency challenges. Voting can take up to three hours, paper and ink are still widely used despite the availability of fingerprint or electronic systems, many polling units lack CCTV surveillance, vote-buying persists, ballot boxes are sometimes transported by tricycle, and insecurity remains a concern at various polling stations.

It is absurd that some polling units are located within politicians' private compounds. Can anyone reasonably expect a candidate opposed by the owner to lose in such a unit? Clearly, the odds are stacked in favour of the host candidate.

All these issues require concrete solutions. While participants in electoral manipulation are culpable, greater responsibility lies with the governing bodies that make such practices possible. The government and the electoral commission (INEC) therefore have crucial roles in ensuring proper regulations are enforced.

Another key area of focus is voter education. Its purpose is to inform eligible voters about the importance of voting, how the process works, and the political choices available. Many citizens are deceived by political antics, remain involved in vote selling, or are used as tools for manipulation. Others struggle to make independent decisions. These realities demonstrate the urgent need for voter education.

Factors such as poverty, political apathy, and self-interest influence these behaviours, but their negative impact on the country cannot be ignored. Some believe that participating in electoral manipulation or vote selling makes no difference, arguing that political parties' manifestos are largely similar. However, meaningful change in all sectors will not occur at once; it begins with individual responsibility. Everyone must play their part by rejecting all forms of electoral malpractice.

Press conferences are another important tool that should be institutionalised by the electoral body. Such conferences should be moderated by journalists and informed activists, under the regulation of

INEC. The purpose is not to disqualify candidates, but to promote competence and healthy competition.

These conferences should be structured so that manifestos can present themselves, explaining why citizens should vote for them. Moderators should pose questions on political, economic, social, and religious issues, allowing candidates from various parties to share their views.

Press conferences are essential because many candidates excel only at reading prepared scripts, some lack the capacity to make sound decisions, some are endorsed due to wealth or influence, and others seek office primarily for personal gain. Press conferences provide a platform to assess competence and inform voters, helping to reduce manipulation and promote accountability.

Another proposal that deserves consideration is the use of legal contracts in politics. A legal contract is an agreement between two or more parties that creates mutual obligations enforceable by law.

Similarly, legal contracts could be introduced in the political sphere. At present, it is very easy for politicians to deceive citizens. The promises we heard in previous political campaigns are often repeated in the current campaign, and the bitter truth is that we might hear the same promises again in future campaigns. We should not continue to tolerate this cycle when we are already familiar with their tactics.

Hence, I propose a contractual framework backed by the Court of Law. All promises made by politicians during speeches or press conferences should be formally recorded in the form of a contract. Such a contract could stipulate that, if a politician occupies a particular office but fails to fulfil their promises by the end of their tenure, they may be required to refund all allowances received from that office.

This suggestion may seem unusual, but it aligns with existing legal principles: if a person deceives another through trickery or deceit, they can be prosecuted in court. Politicians who mislead citizens with false promises should not be exempt from similar accountability.

It may seem amusing, but the fact remains that citizens are often taken for granted. Politicians frequently treat the electorate as a laughingstock. Thus, introducing such a contractual mechanism would help curb these antics and would likely be welcomed by citizens.

Finally, there is a pressing need for severe punishment for those involved in electoral manipulation. Many individuals engage in electoral fraud because the penalties are mild, while some citizens are unaware that such actions are punishable.

Although punishments exist for electoral manipulation, the prevalence of these unlawful acts remains high. This is because existing measures focus primarily on curbing the problem after it occurs, rather than preventing it in the first place.

One of Nigeria's key challenges is the reactive nature of its enforcement system. Punishment is most effective not only when it sanctions wrongdoers but also when it deters others from committing similar acts.

Therefore, punishment should target the mindset and social behaviour of citizens. Thus, what is considered an effective deterrent in one state may function more as encouragement in another, highlighting the need to tailor punitive measures to specific social contexts.